



IF YOU'RE LOOKING to change jobs, now may be a good time because the Indian white-collar job market has well and truly shed its Covid-19 blues to turn red hot. In April 2022, job portal Naukri.com's JobSpeak Index grew 38 per cent year-on-year to 2,863, hovering around a lifetime high. A revival to the pre-pandemic levels also seems well within reach. In the same month, competitor Monster.com recorded the highest level of engagement and job activity on its portal seen during the two pandemic years with its Employment Index hitting 295. It was 296 in March 2020.

The frenetic pace of digital transformation across organisations after the first wave of Covid-19 and the ensuing rush for IT talent in the country drove most of this hiring demand. The IT/tech sector saw 74 per cent hiring growth on Naukri.com during September 2021-February 2022 compared to the year-ago period. "Digital skills are the hottest and demand far outstrips supply. This is one area where there is a gap, despite efforts to upskill and reskill," says Richard Lobo, Executive Vice President and Head of HR at Infosys.

It also brought to the fore a macro trend that IT/tech has gone from being a separate vertical to horizontal across industries. For instance, HDFC Bank found customers willing to accept a digital meeting versus a physical one to discuss financial products. "That puts demand back on the organisation for tech talent, cloud engineering, business applications developers and people who can manage hardware, software and the whole nine yards around it," says CHRO Vinay Razdan.

Meanwhile, as the pandemic waned, retail, travel & hospitality and education & teach-

ing rebounded impressively to become the next three sectors to have registered the highest hiring growth on Naukri.com during the six-month period, with BFSI rounding off the list at the fifth spot (see chart "The Race to Hire").

Looking ahead, digital recruitment platform Taggd's 'Decoding Jobs Sectoral Report' pegs internet businesses, IT/tech, automotive, BFSI and pharma & healthcare as sectors showing the highest hiring intent in 2022. "Compared to last year, there is certainly a hiring boom in April-June. We are seeing increased hiring everywhere, with IT/tech at the top with 70-80 per cent rise. But there is going to be a normalisation," says Taggd President and Founding Member Devashish Sharma. He expects it to slow down to a 50-60 per cent increase in Q2, and a further 20-25 per cent dip in October-March 2023 because a lot of players across industries will be deploying the people they have already hired.

Sanjay Shetty, Director of Professional Search & Selection and Strategic Accounts at recruitment firm Randstad India, picks automobiles as a sector to watch out for. "[Automotive] companies are revamping their entire production chains and you need people with that kind of background and experience such as GIS mapping skills," he says. Tata Motors President & CHRO Ravindra Kumar G.P. adds that the sector is also scouting for designers. "From the vehicle itself to the interiors to the interface of touchscreens which are coming into cars, it's a great opportunity for designers to get into the automobile world today."

In terms of the roles and skills in demand, TeamLease Services Co-founder & Vice Chairman Manish Sabharwal sees IT, manufacturing, sales roles (telecom, financial, FMCG, FMCD), customer services and logistics as areas for growth over the next year. Agreeing on the demand for sales roles, Shetty adds supply chain management, warehouse management and automation-led need for techno-commercial skills to the list. "Project

management, product managers, digital marketing, data analysts, data scientists, blockchain specialists, UX designers, cybersecurity engineers, cloud developers, DevOp engineers are going to be in demand."

Ramped up hiring across sectors means professional services like consulting and accounting are in great demand, says Shetty.

437.2
MILLION
SIZE OF INDIA'S TOTAL
LABOUR FORCE AS OF
APRIL 2022, AS PER CMIE